RLD

SHIFTING SANDS

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NEWLY MINTED RLD chief Jayant Chaudhary garlands a statue of the late farmer leader and ex-PM, 'Bharat Ratna' Charan Singh, at the party office in Lucknow

During the 2022 Uttar Pradesh assembly poll campaign, a statement of Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) chief Jayant Chaudhary had gone viral. "*Chavanni nahin hoon jo palat jaoonga* (I am not a 25 paise coin to flip sides)", he had said, scotching speculation that he was joining the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA). Two years on, with the Centre announcing a Bharat Ratna for ex-prime minister and Jayant's grandfather, the late Charan Singh, and his response on X (formerly Twitter), "*Dil jeet liya* (You've won our hearts)", it was clear how that script was panning out.

Days later, on February 12, the RLD chief confirmed that his party was indeed joining the NDA. "I took this decision after speaking to all my partymen. There was no advance planning, we had to make this decision within a short time because of the circumstances," Jayant told reporters. That would include the Rajya Sabha election on February 27. RLD sources admitted the party's MLAs were being briefed on this.

The RLD's exit is the latest blow to the Opposition I.N.D.I.A. bloc. The party is a key player in western UP, especially among the Jat community that constitutes 15 per cent of the population in the eight districts of the region, including Muzaffarnagar and Baghpat.

Party functionaries claim that Jayant was unhappy in I.N.D.I.A., with differences over seat distribution between the Samajwadi Party (SP) and the RLD. The SP had offered seven seats, but apparently wanted its own candidates to fight on the RLD symbol in three. A senior RLD leader claimed the party wanted the Muzaffarnagar seat, but SP chief Akhilesh Yadav was adamant on keeping it for his candidate, Harendra Malik. 'Just after a meeting with Chaudhary sahab (Jayant)', said the caption of a picture of Akhilesh, Malik and his MLA son, which was posted on X by the SP. An RLD source says "Jayantji took it to heart" as talks on the Muzaffarnagar seat were still on.

Another RLD source says talks between the party and the BJP had been going on for the past two years. Rebuffed in 2022, the BJP apparently approached Jayant again in 2023 with an offer for him to merge the RLD with the party but was again denied. In the new year, the saffron party reportedly revised the offer with three Lok Sabha seats (or two Lok Sabha and one Rajya Sabha), a ministerial berth at the Centre (post-election) and a ministerial berth in UP. The Bharat Ratna was apparently the deal sweetener. As Jayant himself admitted later about the rumours, "*Ab kis moonh se inkaar karoon is sawaal ko* (How do I deny your questions now)?"

JAYANT IS SAID TO HAVE REBUFFED THE BJP TWICE IN THE PAST TWO YEARS, BUT THE 2024 OFFER WAS TOO GOOD TO REFUSE

RLD sources also say that Jayant had increasingly been of the opinion that I.N.D.I.A. didn't have it in it to counter the BJP on the ground, and that his party was better off with the ruling combine. There was also the fear that the party might lose its symbol, the hand pump. In 2023, the Election Commission had withdrawn the RLD's state/ regional party status after it failed to get the minimum 6 per cent of the total vote in the UP assembly election.

Critics, of course, also point to the Chaudhary family's penchant for shifting loyalties. Jayant's father Ajit Singh was a Union minister in numerous regimes since 1989 and there was no side he was not part of at some point or the other. UP-based political analyst Dr Shilp Shikha Singh feels the gains for Jayant will be "short-term" at best. He also believes the RLD chief will forfeit the benefits of the Jat-Muslim unity in west UP that he had been assiduously working on these past few years. The RLD had taken a long time to regain the people's confidence in western UP after the polarising 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots, and Jayant can ill afford a misstep now. ■